

“The Country Was”
By Randall Jarrell

(This is supposed to be a parody of Miss Marianne Moore’s poetry. I hope that it is accurate, admiring, and a little critical.)

The Country Was

All hills and all interesting—in one field
by a barn, by a haystack, were two ‘real
brand new lambs’,
three ewes too ‘uncertain of their
election’ to judge at all or require
much more than
lambs—believed in by another
lamb, perhaps, but not by other

things. The ‘impossible once-or-twice seen’
freak flower ‘marred by dew’, smashed by tears, seems
healthy by
this starveling fantastic sawdust
changeling rag-Sambo scare-crow cur, with its
embryo’s
generalized pink pig’s head—un-
suited for earth, as anyone

but an ewe knows. Yet obviously no one
could ‘harm seriously or curse at’ so in-
nocent a
virgin—much less ‘seethe, butcher, and
so forth and so forth’, as poor Couperin
wrote strongly:
meaning tenors. One thinks all three
his mother and uncertainly

prances to each in his jointless graceless
ungainly knock-kneed stagger, as if fac-
ing nothing
but joy: the maturing half-wit
perfecting in these scrupulous scales its
cadenza,
the overwhelming responses
of the horned ram. The other raises

his head an inch and lets it drop with a
conclusiveness familiar to the ewes graz-

ing by the
barn and to the understanding
farmer as birth, but not yet as hackneyed
to the lamb,
who would perhaps not recognize
birth either. 'Just as advertised'

by the champion of Oxford and other
lost causes such as the classics, as the
man who 'saw
life steadily and saw it whole',
Sophocles got 'about twenty' firsts, still
thought: Better
to be dead than alive but best
of all not to have been born. Test

this response with the dead lamb and it rings
like a bell: iron. The live lamb's sprawling
bright gait is
learned, exact, and in a way
magnificent, but after all play, a
prepara-
tion rather than the essential
life of sheep—dumb, but theirs and real.

[1942]. Published in Randall Jarrell, *The Complete Poems* (1969).